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Unit 8 : Good Intentions

It was Thursday after school. James walked into the house holding his back with a grimace on his face.

"What's wrong with you?" Brett asked.

"My back is so sore," James cried. "I was sitting hunched over in my desk all day long finishing a report."

"The report for Mr. Black?" his curious older brother inquired.

"Yes. It's due tomorrow morning and I have to play basketball tonight," he answered. "But now I think I am too sore to play."

Brett always looked after his younger brother. He didn't like to see James in pain. It really bothered him that his little bro wouldn't be able to play ball. He knew it was everything to him and so he wanted to help.

"Maybe I can give you a massage," Brett offered.

"Do you think it will help?" James didn't think so, but he didn't want to upset his concerned brother by saying no.

"Sure. It will loosen up your muscles and they won't hurt so much," Brett said in a voice that sounded very sure.

James took a seat at the table. His stiff body became even stiffer with the thought of Brett giving him a massage. If it had been a cute girl, he might not have minded the idea so much.

"Just relax," Brett said, trying to reassure James that he knew what he was doing when really he didn't.

Placing his hands on James's shoulders he began rubbing them, slowly and softly at first, then harder and harder. His strong hands squeezed the muscles forcing them to move and drawing out some of the tension.

"That's not so bad is it?" his caring brother asked.

"No. I guess it's alright," he claimed. James felt uncomfortable with his brother touching him, but he didn't want to say anything.

Next, Brett worked inwards toward the neck. He started digging his thumbs into the muscles so as to work out the knots, but he didn't realize his own strength.

"Ouch! That hurts," James screamed and immediately shrugged his shoulders to tell his brother to stop.

"Sorry. Sorry," Brett apologized. "Let me try something else."

James just wanted to go lie down, but his big brother was insistent. This time Brett lightly patted James on the back to try and get the blood flowing to the sore muscles.

"How's that?" Brett asked. "Better?"

"Not bad actually," James said with a surprised voice.

The encouragement excited Brett. He increased the power of the hits thinking that it would be even more effective. His blows became harder and harder. He was now basically beating his brother like a punching bag.

"STOP!" James cried. "That's enough."

"But I thought you were enjoying it," a bewildered Brett uttered.

"I was...until you started beating me like an old mule." James said as he stood up. "Now, not only am I not going to be able to play basketball, but I am going to have big bruises on my back."

The look on Brett's face said it all: he was very sorry. He only wanted to make his little brother feel better, but had instead done the opposite. He lowered his head as guilt and the frustration of failure set in.

"Thanks a bunch for all your help," James said sarcastically as he stormed off to his room. "I'll be lucky if I can play basketball for the next week."



Brett's little brother's words cut deeply into him, but he knew that James would eventually realize that his intentions were good. That, and only that, made him feel a wee bit better.